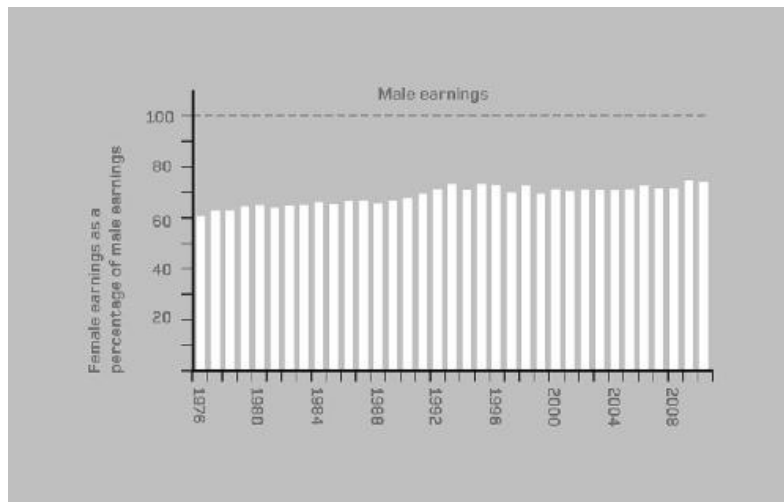


Gender



Over time, female earnings have lagged behind male earnings, as shown in this graph of earnings ratios in Canada from 1976-2011.

Standard economics says little about gender: economies consist of interactions between firms and rational, genderless individuals. Recently, however, some economists have begun to consider the role of gender in more detail. They argue that the usual starting point of 'rational economic man' can't address the discrimination and power imbalances faced by women. What's more, existing ways of measuring the economy don't properly take the contribution of women into account. Women carry out a lot of work within households, caring for children and relatives, cooking and cleaning, and so on. Because this work is usually not paid for in a formal economic transaction, it is not counted in national income. Macroeconomic policies can also affect men and women differently: cutbacks often hit women hardest, especially if health or education cuts increase their responsibilities in the home. GDP is only a partial measure of economic progress, the critics argue: human well-being is dependent on a broad range of factors, including the position of women in society.